Superstore Sales Performance, 2015–2018

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Executive summary

Superstore's sales grew 51% between 2015 and 2018, from $480K to $722K, and totalled $2.26M across the four years. That growth came from more orders (+75%) and more customers (+17%), while the average order got smaller, falling 14% from $506 to $435.

Sales are concentrated in a few places. Q4 brings 38.5% of annual revenue, California and New York make up a third of sales, and the top 20% of customers drive 48%. Corporate and Home Office customers are growing much faster than Consumer customers, while the South region is falling behind.

This report explains each part of the dashboard, what the numbers mean, and what the business could do next. All findings are about sales only, because the data has no profit information.

The four headline numbers:

- **Total sales:** $2.26M
- **Orders:** 4,922
- **Customers:** 793
- **Average order value:** $459

Introduction and objectives

This report explains what four years of Superstore order data (2015 to 2018) show about sales performance, and what the business could do about it. It accompanies an interactive Excel dashboard and is written for business stakeholders who may not work with data every day.

The report answers seven questions, each covered by a section below and by a chart on the dashboard:

1. Are we growing?
2. Where does the growth come from?
3. When do customers buy?
4. What do we sell?
5. Where do we sell?
6. Who buys from us?

7. How do we ship?

The scope is sales performance only. Profitability is outside the scope because the data contains no profit information.

Data and methodology

The analysis uses the Superstore sales dataset: 9,800 order lines in the United States, dated 3 January 2015 to 30 December 2018. After cleaning (see Appendix A), 9,799 lines remain, covering 4,922 orders and 793 customers. The data was cleaned and analysed in Microsoft Excel, and the dashboard is built in one workbook from formula-based summary tables and Excel charts.

The metrics are defined as follows:

- **Sales:** the sum of the Sales value of the order lines in scope. Amounts are shown in US dollars, which is an assumption because the data does not state a currency.
- **Orders:** the number of distinct Order IDs. One order can contain several lines.
- **Customers:** the number of distinct Customer IDs.
- **Average order value:** total sales divided by the number of orders.
- **Growth:** the percentage change in sales between two periods. "2015 to 2018" compares the first and last years of the data.
- **Share of sales:** a category, region, segment or shipping mode's sales as a percentage of total sales.

How to read the dashboard

The dashboard is an Excel workbook with a Select year dropdown at the top. Choosing a year, or All, updates the four headline numbers and every chart except Sales by year, which always shows all four years. The tables behind each chart are on the Analysis sheet, and the cleaned data is on the Data sheet.

This table shows where to find the evidence for each section of the report:

Report section	Where to see it on the dashboard
1. Are we growing?	Sales by year chart
2. Where does the growth come from?	Headline numbers (orders, customers, average order value): select each year to compare

Report section	Where to see it on the dashboard
3. When do customers buy?	Sales by month chart: add three months together for the quarter shares
4. What do we sell?	Sales by sub-category chart. Category totals are on the Analysis sheet
5. Where do we sell?	Sales by region chart and Top 10 states chart
6. Who buys from us?	Sales by customer segment chart. Top 10 customers are on the Analysis sheet
7. How do we ship?	Sales by shipping mode chart. Average days to ship are on the Analysis sheet

1. Are we growing?

Yes. Sales were $480K in 2015, dipped 4% to $459K in 2016, then rebounded with growth of 31% in 2017 ($600K) and 20% in 2018 ($722K).

The 2016 dip is worth remembering. It shows that growth is not automatic, and it is the only year when sales fell.

2. Where does the growth come from?

The growth comes from volume, not from bigger orders. Between 2015 and 2018:

- Orders rose 75%, from 947 to 1,661.
- Customers rose 17%, from 589 to 690.
- Sales per customer rose 28%, from $814 to $1,046, so existing customers are buying more often.
- The average order value fell 14%, from $506 to $435.

In plain terms: customers are ordering more often, but each order is smaller. That makes upselling and bundling a clear opportunity.

3. When do customers buy?

Sales are strongly seasonal, and the pattern repeats every year. Q4 brings 38.5% of annual sales, Q3 brings 26.7%, Q2 brings 19.3% and Q1 only 15.5%. September, November and December together account for 43% of all sales.

This matters for planning. Stock, staffing and promotions need to peak from September to December, and Q1 is the quiet period where a targeted promotion could add the most.

4. What do we sell?

Technology is the largest category at 36.6% of sales, followed by Furniture (32.2%) and Office Supplies (31.2%). Growth tells a different story: from 2015 to 2018, Office Supplies grew 61%, Technology 55% and Furniture only 36%.

At sub-category level, Phones ($328K) and Chairs ($323K) lead. At the other end, Fasteners, Labels, Envelopes and Art together make up just 2.6% of sales.

Two cautions apply:

- Low sales does not mean a product should be dropped. Without profit data, we can only say where the revenue comes from.
- Big-ticket items swing results. Copiers grew from $11K to $63K (+480%), while Machines fell 30%. One Canon copier alone is worth $61.6K, or 2.7% of all sales, so a few large orders can change a sub-category's trend.

5. Where do we sell?

The West (31.4%) and East (29.6%) generate 61% of sales, followed by Central (21.8%) and the South (17.2%). By state, California ($446K) and New York ($306K) together make up 33% of all sales.

The regions are also growing at very different speeds. From 2015 to 2018 the West grew 70%, the East 65%, Central 38% and the South only 18%. The South's sales dropped 32% in 2016, from $103K to $70K, and it has only recently recovered to $122K.

6. Who buys from us?

Consumers are half of sales (50.8%), followed by Corporate (30.4%) and Home Office (18.8%). The growth is elsewhere: from 2015 to 2018, Corporate sales grew 85% and Home Office 77%, compared with 25% for Consumer.

Sales are also concentrated among a small group of customers. The top 20% of the 793 customers drive 48% of sales, so keeping those accounts happy is important.

7. How do we ship?

Standard Class carries 59% of sales and takes 5.0 days on average. Second Class (20% of sales) averages 3.2 days, First Class (15%) averages 2.2 days, and Same Day (5.5%) ships within the day. The average time to ship has stayed at about four days in every year, so delivery speed is stable.

Discussion

Taken together, the findings describe a growing business that depends on a few things going right.

Growth rests on order volume. Sales rose 51% because orders rose 75%, while the average order fell 14%. Sales per customer rose 28%, so customers are coming back more often. If order volume stalls, sales will stall with it unless order values recover.

Sales are concentrated in time, place and customers. Q4 brings 38.5% of sales, California and New York make up 33%, and the top 20% of customers drive 48%. This concentration is efficient, but a weak holiday season, a regional problem or the loss of a few key accounts would hit sales hard.

The biggest opportunities sit where growth is uneven. The South grew 18% against 70% in the West. Q1 is the weakest quarter at 15.5% of sales. Corporate and Home Office customers are growing three times faster than Consumer customers. Each of these is a place where focused effort could change the overall result.

Recommendations

These are suggestions based on sales data. They should be tested before large decisions are made.

1. **Prepare for the September to December peak.** Align stock, staffing and campaigns with Q3 and Q4, which bring over 65% of sales.
2. **Lift Q1.** Test promotions in the quietest quarter to smooth out the year.
3. **Raise the average order value.** Try bundles, volume discounts or recommended add-ons, since orders are getting smaller.
4. **Investigate the South.** Find out why growth is only 18% and why 2016 fell so sharply.
5. **Invest in business customers.** Corporate and Home Office are the fastest-growing segments.
6. **Protect key accounts.** Track the top 20% of customers and review them regularly.

7. **Collect profit data.** Before deciding to expand or cut any product range, add profit and discount information to see what is actually profitable.

Limitations

- The dataset has sales only. It has no profit, quantity or discount, so nothing here says which products or regions are profitable.
- The data covers four years, so long-term trends are limited.
- Some product IDs have more than one product name. This does not affect the results, because the analysis is done at category and sub-category level.
- Large single orders can distort individual sub-categories, as with copiers.

Conclusion

Superstore grew sales by 51% in four years, driven by more orders and more customers. Growth is strongest in the West and East and among Corporate and Home Office customers, and weakest in the South. Sales are concentrated in Q4, in California and New York, and among the top 20% of customers.

The most useful next step is to add profit and discount data to the analysis. With it, the business can see which products, regions and customers are actually profitable, and turn the recommendations in this report into confident decisions.

Appendix A: Data preparation

The raw file contained 9,800 rows. Cleaning steps in Excel:

- Converted the dates from text into real dates.
- Removed 1 duplicate row, leaving 9,799 rows.
- Filled 11 missing postal codes, all for Burlington, Vermont, with 05401 (an assumption).
- Added Year, Month, Quarter and Ship Days columns, plus three flag columns (1 marks the first row of each order or customer) used to count distinct orders and customers.
- Built formula-based summary tables and charts from the cleaned data to create the dashboard.